

LIVING SCULPTURES

In the short period of peace between the two world wars designers turned to the classical era of ancient Greece and Rome. To those reeling from the horrors of the Great War, classical antiquity stood for a golden time of proportion, pared-back beauty, purity, and a life-affirming appreciation of the human body.

French fashion designer Madeleine Vionnet (1876–1975) created her womenswear shapes of the 1930s from the drapery and perfect body forms of classical statues. Her twin concerns were fabric and the body. Famous for her genius with the bias cut, she draped fluid materials such as silk crêpe to create simple, loosely structured daywear and dramatic eveningwear with minimal sewing and embellishment and without corsetry or petticoats. Her garments clung sensuously, shocking her customers. Early 1920s dresses with pointed drapery resemble the Greek peplos, while a dress from 1918–19, which hangs from the shoulders with an uneven hemline and cowl neckline, recalls the *chlamys* and *chiton* from ancient Rome.

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She made a Greek dress in a way the Greeks could never have imagined; there was nothing archaic about her lines. Everything Vionnet created had a cling or a flow, and women dressed by her were like moving sculptures.

CECIL BEATON

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THE CLASSICAL MUSE ▷

This photograph by leading photographer George Hoyningen-Huene, c.1931, shows Sonia, Vionnet's favourite model, looking like a graceful dancing figure from a Greek vase in her pale silk crêpe *romaine* pyjamas and long scarf. The model had to lie down for the photographer to achieve the desired effect.

